CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PEST CONTROL TECH IN THE AI ERA

Roaches, rodents and termites never got the memo about recessions. Licensed, routed, and quietly one of the steadiest paychecks in the trades.

★ TL;DR — Median around $45K, with training in the 6–12 month band and a state applicator license as the entry ticket. The catch: you work where bugs live — crawlspaces, restaurants at dawn, and other people's worst infestations. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

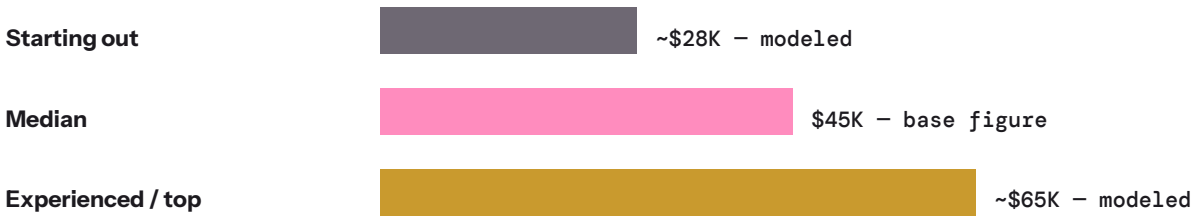
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Works because: pests are a permanent condition of buildings, and recurring service contracts make revenue boringly predictable.
- Bites because: chemical exposure discipline is serious, and the work includes the grossest corners of other people's properties.
- AI angle: minimal. Smart traps report activity; inspection, exclusion and treatment are a human walking the building with a flashlight.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Pest Control Tech is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PEST CONTROL TECH ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Inspect homes and businesses for pests and the conditions inviting them — moisture, gaps, food, harborage

✓ Apply treatments: sprays, baits, traps, dusts — the right material, in the right place, at the legal label rate

✓ Seal entry points and advise owners on exclusion and sanitation

✓ Run a recurring route and document every service for compliance and customers

Think: a detective who also does the arresting — find how they got in, why they stay, end it, and keep them out.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Remote sensors in traps and route software changed reporting, not the work: identifying species, finding harborages and applying chemicals legally still require a licensed human on site.	Inspection judgment — the difference between treating a symptom and solving an infestation — plus customer psychology: people are embarrassed, scared or furious about bugs, usually all three.

⚠ **The license is not paperwork theater: pesticide law is strict, labels are law, and misuse has real health and legal consequences. Companies carry the insurance; you carry the discipline, every stop, every day.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Independent route work with a company truck and phone ✓ Recurring-contract stability rare in the trades ✓ Every stop is a small mystery with a visible result	✗ Crawlspaces, attics, dumpsters and hoarded kitchens ✗ Chemicals demand respect forever, not just in training ✗ Customers at their most stressed and least rational

Good fit? You're observant, unflappable and unbothered by creepy-crawlies; you follow safety rules when nobody's watching.
Bad fit? You're squeamish, sloppy with chemicals, or hate working alone on a route.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — TECHNICIAN AT A PEST COMPANY	DOOR B — TERMITE / WILDLIFE / SPECIALTY TRACKS

Companies hire trainees, train them in-house, and put them through the state applicator licensing process. You'll ride routes, learn products and label law, and take your own route once licensed — the standard, steadiest door in the industry.	Specialize from the start or pivot in: termite inspection and treatment, wildlife exclusion, or bedbug work — higher tickets, deeper skills, and in some states additional license categories. Specialty techs are the industry's premium labor.

Smart move: Stack license categories as fast as your state allows (general pest, termite, fumigation where offered). Each category widens what you can legally sell and do — licensed breadth is literally priced into your pay.
Where you land after: Trainee → licensed route tech → senior/specialist tech → service manager or your own pest company.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET HIRED	LEARN PRODUCTS	PASS THE	RUN YOUR	ADD CATEGORIES	MANAGE OR

STEP 1 — Get hired as a trainee

FREE · TODAY

- Pest companies hire for attitude and driving record; entomology can be taught, reliability can't.
- A clean license (driving) and background check are standard gates — you'll enter homes alone.

STEP 2 — Learn products and label law

MONTHS 1-6

- Pesticide classes, formulations, safety data, and the rule that the label is the law.
- PPE and exposure discipline from day one — this is a career-long habit, not a unit in a course.

STEP 3 — Pass the state applicator exam

EXAM + STATE LICENSE

- Sit your state's pesticide applicator licensing exam (core plus category) under your company's certification structure.
- The license converts you from trainee to route-carrying tech — and your pay moves with it.

STEP 4 — Run your own route

PAID · MONTHS

- Recurring residential and commercial stops: inspect, treat, document, advise.
- Retention is your report card — customers who stay are customers you solved.

STEP 5 — Add categories and specialties YEAR 1+

- Termite (WDO) work, bedbug programs, wildlife exclusion — the higher-ticket shelves.
- Each added license category is a raise you give yourself.

STEP 6 — Manage or own YEAR 2+

- Service management: routes, techs, compliance — the office end of the license.
- Ownership: your own company once your licensing and insurance stack is complete.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: apply to three pest companies; check your state's applicator license categories.
- □ Days 1–30: ride-alongs and product/label training; PPE habits formed now, permanently.
- □ Days 31–60: supervised treatments; exam study for core and general-pest categories.
- □ Days 61–90: applicator exam sat or scheduled; first solo stops under the company umbrella.
- □ Day 90: a licensed-or-nearly tech with route experience — the industry's standard, employable shape.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ FIND THE DOOR THEY USED. CLOSE IT. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.